

His character combined an iron will with a neurotic sensibility that indulged feelings of loss and longing. This side of his personality fed into his music. Written between 1883 and 1885, his song cycle *Lieder eines fahrenden Gesellen* (Songs of a Wayfarer) set his own poems inspired by an unhappy love affair with a soprano at the Kassel opera house, Johanna Richter. The original five-movement version of his First Symphony, premiered in 1889, was partly stimulated by his troubled relationship with a married woman, Marion von Weber, in Leipzig.

“ Gustav lives his life, and I, too, must live his life. ”

ALMA MAHLER

Death seemed ever present—his mother, father, and one of his sisters died in 1889; his brother, Otto, shot himself in 1895. Mahler’s Second and Third Symphonies, mostly written on holidays at Steinbach between 1893 and 1896, were programmatic pieces expressing his Nietzschean vision of death overcome by eternal renewal.

In 1897, aged 37, Mahler took up the prestigious post of musical director at the Vienna Hofoper (Court Opera). As a condition of the job, which was not open to members of the Jewish faith, he converted to Catholicism. Imposing his will upon singers, orchestra, and public alike, he transformed the opera’s stagings, the quality of the music, and the atmosphere in which it